Literature Screener: alpha tester guide

Alpha test version · Thank you for helping test this app before it is shared more widely.

Literature Screener is a desktop app for biomedical literature reviews. You search PubMed, keep the results in a project folder on your own computer, and screen titles and abstracts as *Include*, *Exclude* or *Unsure*. Every search and decision is recorded, so the review can be reproduced. This is an **alpha**: expect rough edges, and please tell us about every one you find.

1. Install

Everything is on one page: **yifan-hu1.github.io/literature-screener-app**. It suggests the right download for your computer.

Mac

1. On the download page, click **Download for Mac**. The same file works on Macs with an Apple chip or an Intel processor.
2. Open the `.dmg` and drag **Literature Screener** into **Applications**.
3. Open it. The first time, macOS says it cannot verify the app (test versions are not yet signed with Apple). Click **Done** (or **OK**), then go to **System Settings** → **Privacy & Security**, scroll down and click **Open Anyway**. This is needed only once.

Windows

1. Download the Windows installer and double-click it. It installs for your user account only and **does not need administrator rights**; the app opens when done.
2. If “Windows protected your PC” appears, click **More info** → **Run anyway** (test versions are not yet signed).
3. If your computer does not allow installing, use the **portable version** (link on the download page): extract the zip and double-click **Literature Screener.exe**.
4. Some university-managed PCs block unsigned programs entirely. If so, let us know; please don't work around your IT rules.

2. First steps

- Enter your name when asked. It is saved with each screening decision.
- Create a project in an **ordinary local folder**, not one synced by OneDrive, Dropbox, iCloud or Google Drive (syncing while the app is open can damage the project). On university Windows PCs, “Documents” and “Desktop” are often synced by OneDrive; the app warns you if it detects this. A folder such as `C:\Users\<you>\LiteratureProjects` is a safe choice.
- Optional: in **Settings**, add your email for NCBI, and a free NCBI API key if you will import large searches.

3. Things to try (about 45 minutes)

Use a topic from your own work if you can. Real questions find the most useful problems.

> **Task 1: Set up a project.**
> Create a project with a research question and a few inclusion and exclusion criteria.

> **Task 2: Build a search.**
> In **Search PubMed**, put each idea in its own concept with synonyms, use **Suggest MeSH terms**, choose organisms or systems (try “All of these”), and optionally **Primary research only**. Compare the result count with the same query on pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov.

> **Task 3: Collect papers.**
> Use **Import all** on one search (a few hundred results is ideal). Run a different search and save two or three papers by hand with **Save to project**.

> **Task 4: Screen.**
> Screen about 30 papers with the keyboard: I include, U unsure, E exclude (then a number for the reason), ← → to move. Change one decision, add a note, and correct an organism label (✓ Confirm / ✗ Doesn't apply).

> **Task 5: Organise and export.**
> In the **Library**, filter (e.g. by organism), create a collection and add papers to it, then export **CSV** (open in Excel) and **RIS** (import into Zotero, EndNote or Mendeley). On the Overview page, export the **PRISMA summary**.

> **Task 6: Updates and persistence.**
> On the Overview page, set an imported search to **Keep up to date** and press **Check now**. Quit the app, reopen it, and check that everything is still there. Make a copy with **Back up project…**.

4. Reporting problems and ideas

Please report anything that breaks, confuses you, or gives a **scientifically wrong result** (for example a paper wrongly filtered out, a wrong organism label, or counts that don't add up). These matter most.

- Say what you did, what you expected, and what happened. A screenshot helps.
- In **Settings** → **About**, click **Copy details for a bug report** and paste the result into the form (app version, operating system and recent error messages).
- Send it with the feedback form: in the app, **Settings** → **About** → **Send feedback**, or go to **yifan-hu1.github.io/literature-screener-app/feedback**.

5. Your data

- Projects, decisions and notes stay **on your computer**, in the project folder you chose.
- Only your **search queries** (and, if you entered them, your NCBI email and API key) are sent to PubMed (NCBI). There is no tracking and no AI in this version.
- New test versions keep working with your existing projects. Still, use **Back up project…** before installing a new version.

6. Known limitations of this alpha

- PubMed only. No AI screening, full-text retrieval or supplementary files yet.
- One search can import at most 10,000 results (a PubMed limit); larger searches must be narrowed.
- Automatic updates run only while the app is open.
- No automatic app updates: new versions appear on the download page (we will let you know). Installing over the old version keeps your projects.
- Security warnings on first launch, as described above, until the app is signed.
